9 The Writing Skills Questions

The questions in the writing skills sections test your ability to recognize clear, correct standard written English, the kind of writing your college professors will expect on the papers you write for them. You'll be expected to know basic grammar, such as subject-verb agreement, pronoun-antecedent agreement, correct verb tense, correct sentence structure, and correct diction. You'll need to know how to recognize a dangling participle and how to spot when two parts of a sentence are not clearly connected. You'll also need to know when a paragraph is (or isn't) properly developed and organized.

Identifying Sentence Errors

There are three different kinds of questions on the writing skills sections of the SAT: identifying sentence errors, improving sentences, and improving paragraphs. Almost half of them are identifying sentence errors questions in which you have to find an error in the underlined section of a sentence. You do not have to correct the sentence or explain what is wrong. Here are the directions.

> The sentences in this section may contain errors in grammar, usage, choice of words, or idioms. Either there is just one error in a sentence or the sentence is correct. Some words or phrases are underlined and lettered; everything else in the sentence is correct.
>
> If an underlined word or phrase is incorrect, choose that letter; if the sentence is correct, select No error. Then blacken the appropriate space on your answer sheet.
>
> Example:
>
> The region has a climate so severe that (A) plants growing there (B) rarely had been (C) more than twelve inches high. (D) No error (E)
>
> Ⓐ Ⓑ ● Ⓓ Ⓔ

Testing Tactics

Tactic 1 — Remember that the error, if there is one, must be in the underlined part of the sentence.

You don't have to worry about making improvements that could be made in the rest of the sentence. For example, if you have a sentence in which the subject is plural and the verb is singular, you could call either one the error. But if only the verb is underlined, the error for that sentence is the verb.

Tactic 2 — Use your ear for the language.

Remember, you don't have to name the error, or be able to explain why it is wrong. All you have to do is recognize that something *is* wrong. On the early, easy questions in the set, if a word or phrase sounds wrong to you, it probably is, even if you don't know why.

Tactic 3 — Look first for the most common errors.

Most of the sentences will have errors. If you are having trouble finding mistakes, check for some of the more common ones: subject-verb agreement, pronoun-antecedent problems, misuse of adjectives and adverbs, dangling modifiers. But look for errors only in the underlined parts of the sentence.



Remember that not every sentence contains an error.

Ten to twenty percent of the time, the sentence is correct as it stands. Do not get so caught up in hunting for errors that you start seeing errors that aren't there. If no obvious errors strike your eye and the sentence sounds natural to your ear, go with choice E: No error.

> Mr. Brown is (A) one of the commuters who takes (B) the 7:30 train from (C) Brooktown every (D) morning. No error (E)

Since *who* refers to *commuters*, it is plural, and needs a plural verb. Therefore, the error is choice B. If you were writing this sentence yourself, you could correct it in any number of other ways. You could say, "Mr. Brown is a commuter who takes . . ." or "Mr. Brown, a commuter, takes . . ." or "Mr. Brown, who is one of the commuters, takes . . ." However, the actual question doesn't offer you any of these possibilities. You have to choose from the underlined choices. Don't waste your time considering other ways to fix the sentence.

See if your ear helps you with this question.

> In my history class (A) I learned why (B) the American colonies opposed the British (C), how they organized the militia, and the work of the Continental Congress (D). No error (E)

The last part of this sentence probably sounds funny to you—awkward, strange, wooden. You may not know exactly what it is, but something sounds wrong here. If you followed your instincts and chose choice D as the error, you would be right. The error is a lack of parallel structure. The sentence is listing three things you learned, and they should all be in the same form. Your ear expects the pattern to be the same. Since the first two items listed are clauses, the third should be too: "In my history class I learned why the American colonies opposed the British, how they organized the militia, and how the Continental Congress worked."

> Marilyn and I (A) ran as fast (B) as we could, but we missed our train, which (C) made us (D) late for work. No error (E)

Imagine that you have this sentence, and you can't see what is wrong with it. Start at the beginning and check each answer choice. *I* is part of the subject, so it is the right case: after all, you wouldn't say "Me ran fast." *Fast* can be an adverb, so it is being used correctly here. *Which* is a pronoun, and needs a noun for its antecedent. The only available noun is *train*, but that doesn't make sense (the train didn't make us late—*missing* the train made us late). So there is your error, choice C.

Once you have checked each answer choice, if you still can't find an error, choose choice E, "No error." A certain number of questions have no errors.

Improving Sentences

The most numerous questions in the two writing skills sections involve spotting the form of a sentence that works best. In these improving sentence questions, you will be presented with five different versions of the same sentence; you must choose the best one. Here are the directions:

> Some or all parts of the following sentences are underlined. The first answer choice, (A), simply repeats the underlined part of the sentence. The other four choices present four alternative ways to phrase the underlined part. Select the answer that produces the most effective sentence, one that is clear and exact, and blacken the appropriate space on your answer sheet. In selecting your choice, be sure that it is standard written English, and that it expresses the meaning of the original sentence.
>
> Example:
>
> The first biography of author Eudora Welty came out in 1998 and she was 89 years old at the time.
>
> (A) and she was 89 years old at the time
> (B) at the time when she was 89
> (C) upon becoming an 89 year old
> (D) when she was 89
> (E) at the age of 89 years old
>
> Ⓐ Ⓑ Ⓒ ● Ⓔ

Testing Tactics

Tactic 1 — If you spot an error in the underlined section, eliminate any answer that repeats it.

If something in the underlined section of a sentence correction question strikes you as an obvious error, you can immediately ignore any answer choices that repeat it. Remember, you still don't have to be able to explain what is wrong. You just need to find a correct equivalent. If the error you found in the underlined section is absent from more than one of the answer choices, look over those choices again to see if they add any new errors.

Tactic 2 — If you don't spot the error in the underlined section, look for changes in the answer choices.

Sometimes it's hard to spot what's wrong with the underlined section in a sentence correction question. When that happens, turn to the answer choices. Find the changes in the answers. The changes will tell you what kind of error is being tested. When you substitute the answer choices in the original sentence, ask yourself which of these choices makes the sentence seem clearest to you. That may well be the correct answer choice.

Tactic 3 — Make sure that all parts of the sentence are logically connected.

Not all parts of a sentence are created equal. Some parts should be subordinated to the rest, connected with subordinating conjunctions or relative pronouns, not just added on with *and*. Overuse of *and* frequently makes sentences sound babyish. Compare "We had dinner at the Hard Rock Cafe, and we went to a concert" with "After we had dinner at the Hard Rock Cafe, we went to a concert."

Tactic 4 — Make sure that all parts of a sentence given in a series are similar in form.

If they are not, the sentence suffers from a lack of parallel structure. The sentence "I'm taking classes in algebra, history, and how to speak French" lacks parallel structure. *Algebra* and *history* are nouns, names of subjects. The third subject should also be a noun: *conversational French.*

Tactic 5 — Pay particular attention to the shorter answer choices.

(This tactic also applies to certain paragraph correction questions.) Good prose is economical. Often the correct answer choice will be the shortest, most direct way of making a point. If you spot no grammatical errors or errors in logic in a concise answer choice, it may well be right.

> Being as I had studied for the test with a tutor, I was confident.
>
> (A) Being as I had studied for the test
> (B) Being as I studied for the test
> (C) Since I studied for the test
> (D) Since I had studied for the test
> (E) Because I studied for the test

Since you immediately recognize that *Being as* is not acceptable as a conjunction in standard written English, you can eliminate choices A and B right away. But you also know that both *Since* and *Because* are perfectly acceptable conjunctions, so you have to look more closely at choices C, D, and E. The only other changes these choices make are in the tense of the verb. Since the studying occurred before the taking of the test, the past perfect tense, *had studied*, is correct, so the answer is choice D. Even if you hadn't known that, you could have figured it out. Since *Because* and *Since* are both acceptable conjunctions, and since choices C and E both use the same verb, *studied,* in the simple past tense, those two choices must be wrong. Otherwise, they would both be right, and the SAT doesn't have questions with two right answers.

> Even the play's most minor characters work together with extraordinary skill, their interplay creates a moving theatrical experience.
>
> (A) their interplay creates a moving theatrical experience
> (B) a moving theatrical experience is created by their interplay
> (C) and their interplay creates a moving theatrical experience
> (D) and a moving theatrical experience being the creation of their interplay
> (E) with their interplay they create a moving theatrical experience

Look at the underlined section of the sentence. Nothing seems wrong with it. It could stand on its own as an independent sentence: *Their interplay creates a moving theatrical experience*. Choices B and E are similar to it, for both could stand as independent sentences. Choices C and D, however, are not independent sentences; both begin with the linking word *and*. The error needing correction here is the common comma splice, in which two sentences are

carelessly linked with only a comma. Choice C corrects this error in the simplest way possible, adding the word *and* to tie these sentences together.

The rock star always had enthusiastic fans and they loved him.

(A) and they loved him
(B) and they loving him
(C) what loved him
(D) who loved him
(E) which loved him

The original version of this sentence doesn't have any grammatical errors, but it is a poor sentence because it doesn't connect its two clauses logically. The second clause ("and they loved him") is merely adding information about the fans, so it should be turned into an adjective clause, introduced by a relative pronoun. Choices D and E both seem to fit, but you know that *which* should never be used to refer to people, so choice D is obviously the correct answer.

In this chapter we'll analyze both types of questions, suggest useful techniques for tackling them, providing some sample items for you to try.

(A) suggest useful techniques for tackling them, providing some sample items for you to try
(B) suggest useful techniques for tackling them, providing some sample items which you can try
(C) suggest useful tactics for tackling them, and provide some sample items for you to try
(D) and suggest useful techniques for tackling them by providing some sample items for you to try
(E) having suggested useful techniques for tackling them and provided some sample items for you to try

To answer questions like this correctly, you must pay particular attention to what the sentence means. You must first decide whether *analyzing, suggesting,* and *providing* are logically equal in importance here. Since they are—all are activities that "we" will do—they should be given equal emphasis. Only choice C provides the proper parallel structure.

The turning point in the battle of Waterloo probably was Blucher, who was arriving in time to save the day.

(A) Blucher, who was arriving
(B) Blucher, in that he arrived
(C) Blucher's arrival
(D) when Blucher was arriving
(E) that Blucher had arrived

Which answer choice uses the fewest words? Choice C, *Blucher's arrival.* It also happens to be the right answer.

Choice C is both concise in style and correct in grammar. Look back at the original sentence. Strip it of its modifiers, and what is left? "The turning point . . . was Blucher." A turning point is not a person; it is a *thing.* The turning point in the battle was not Blucher, but Blucher's *action,* the thing he did. The correct answer is choice C, *Blucher's arrival.* Pay particular attention to such concise answer choices. If a concise choice sounds natural when you substitute it for the original underlined phrase, it's a reasonable guess.

Improving Paragraphs

In the improving paragraph questions, you will confront a flawed student essay followed by six questions. In some cases, you must select the answer choice that best rewrites and combines portions of two separate sentences. In others, you must decide where in the essay a sentence best fits. In still others, you must choose what sort of additional information would most strengthen the writer's argument. Here are the directions.

The passage below is the unedited draft of a student's essay. Parts of the essay need to be rewritten to make the meaning clearer and more precise. Read the essay carefully.

The essay is followed by six questions about changes that might improve all or part of the organization, development, sentence structure, use of language, appropriateness to the audience, or use of standard written English. In each case, choose the answer that most clearly and effectively expresses the student's intended meaning. Indicate your choice by blackening the corresponding space on the answer sheet.

[1] Nowadays the average cost of a new home in San Francisco is over $500,000. [2] For this reason it is not surprising that people are talking about a cheaper new type of home called a Glidehouse. [3] The Glidehouse is a type of factory-built housing. [4] It was designed by a young woman architect named Michelle Kaufmann. [5] Michelle was disgusted by having to pay $600,000 for a fixer-upper. [6] So she designed a kind of a modular house with walls that glide.

Sentences 3, 4, and 5 (reproduced below) could best be written in which of the following ways?

The Glidehouse is a type of factory-built housing. It was designed by a young woman architect named Michelle Kaufmann. Michelle was disgusted by having to pay $600,000 for a fixer-upper.

(A) (Exactly as shown above)
(B) The Glidehouse typifies factory-built housing. A young woman architect named Michelle Kaufmann designed it, having been disgusted at having to pay $600,000 for a fixer-upper.

(C) The Glidehouse is a type of factory-built home, it was a young woman architect named Michelle Kaufmann who designed it because she resented having to pay $600,000 for a fixer-upper.
(D) An example of housing that has been built in a factory, the Glidehouse was the design of a young woman architect named Michelle Kaufmann whom having to pay $600,000 for a fixer-upper resented.
(E) The Glidehouse, a factory-built home, was designed by the architect Michelle Kaufmann, who resented having to pay $600,000 for a fixer-upper.

In the original essay, sentences 3, 4, and 5 are wordy and rely heavily on passive voice constructions. Read aloud, they sound choppy. Choice E combines these three simple sentences into a single sentence that is both coherent and grammatically correct.

Testing Tactics



First read the passage; then read the questions.

Whether you choose to skim the student essay quickly or to read it closely, you need to have a reasonable idea of what the student author is trying to say before you set out to correct this rough first draft.



First tackle the questions that ask you to improve individual sentences; then tackle the ones that ask you to strengthen the passage as a whole.

In the sentence correction questions, you've just been weeding out ineffective sentences and selecting effective ones. Here you're doing more of the same. It generally takes less time to spot an effective sentence than it does to figure out a way to strengthen an argument or link up two paragraphs.



Consider whether the addition of signal words or phrases—transitions—would strengthen the passage or particular sentences within it.

If the essay is trying to contrast two ideas, it might benefit from the addition of a contrast signal.

Contrast Signals: *although, despite, however, in contrast, nevertheless, on the contrary, on the other hand.*

If one portion of the essay is trying to support or continue a thought developed elsewhere in the passage, it might benefit from the addition of a support signal.

Support Signals: *additionally, furthermore, in addition, likewise, moreover.*

If the essay is trying to indicate that one thing causes another, it might benefit from the addition of a cause and effect signal.

Cause and Effect Signals: *accordingly, as a result of, because, consequently, hence, therefore, thus.*

Pay particular attention to answer choices that contain such signal words.



When you tackle the questions, *go back to the passage* to verify each answer choice.

See whether your revised version of a particular sentence sounds right in its context. Ask yourself whether your choice follows naturally from the sentence before.

Common Grammar and Usage Errors

Some errors are more common than others in this section. Here are a dozen that appear frequently on the examination. Watch out for them when you do the practice exercises and when you take the SAT.

The Run-On Sentence

Mary's party was very exciting, it lasted until 2 A.M.
It is raining today, I need a raincoat.

You may also have heard this error called a comma splice. It can be corrected by making two sentences instead of one:

Mary's party was very exciting. It lasted until 2 A.M.

or by using a semicolon in place of the comma:

Mary's party was very exciting; it lasted until 2 A.M.

or by proper compounding:

Mary's party was very exciting and lasted until 2 A.M.

You can also correct this error with proper subordination. The second example above could be corrected:

Since it is raining today, I need a raincoat.

It is raining today, so I need a raincoat.

The Sentence Fragment

Since John was talking during the entire class, making it impossible for anyone to concentrate.

This is the opposite of the first error. Instead of too much in one sentence, here you have too little. Do not be misled by the length of the fragment. It must have a main clause before it can be a complete sentence. All you have in this example is the cause. You still need a result. For example, the sentence could be corrected:

Since John was talking during the entire class, making it impossible for anyone to concentrate, the teacher made him stay after school.

Error in the Case of a Noun or Pronoun

Between you and I, this test is not really very difficult.

Case problems usually involve personal pronouns, which are in the nominative case (*I, he, she, we, they, who*) when they are used as subjects or predicate nominatives, and in the objective case (*me, him, her, us, them, whom*) when they are used as direct objects, indirect objects, and objects of prepositions. In this example, if you realize that *between* is a preposition, you know that *I* should be changed to the objective *me* because it is the object of a preposition.

Error in Subject-Verb Agreement

Harvard College, along with several other Ivy League schools, are sending students to the conference.

Phrases starting with *along with* or *as well as* or *in addition to* that are placed in between the subject and the verb do not affect the verb. The subject of this sentence is *Harvard College,* so the verb should be *is sending.*

There is three bears living in that house.

Sentences that begin with *there* almost always have the subject after the verb. The subject of this sentence is *bears,* so the verb should be *are.*

Error in Pronoun-Number Agreement

Every one of the girls on the team is trying to do their best.

Every pronoun must have a specific noun or noun substitute for an antecedent, and it must agree with that antecedent in number (singular or plural). In this example, *their* refers to *one* and must be singular:

Every one of the girls on the team is trying to do her best.

Error in the Tense or Form of a Verb

After the sun set behind the mountain, a cool breeze sprang up and brought relief from the heat.

Make sure the verbs in a sentence appear in the proper sequence of tenses, so that it is clear what happened when. Since, according to the sentence, the breeze did not appear until after the sun had finished setting, the setting belongs in the past perfect tense:

After the sun had set behind the mountain, a cool breeze sprang up and brought relief from the heat.

Error in Logical Comparison

I can go to California or Florida. I wonder which is best.

When you are comparing only two things, you should use the comparative form of the adjective, not the superlative:

I wonder which is better.

Comparisons must also be complete and logical.

The rooms on the second floor are larger than the first floor.

It would be a strange building that had rooms larger than an entire floor. Logically, this sentence should be corrected to:

The rooms on the second floor are larger than those on the first floor.

Adjective and Adverb Confusion

She did good on the test.

They felt badly about leaving their friends.

These are the two most common ways that adjectives and adverbs are misused. In the first example, when you are talking about how someone did, you want the adverb *well,* not the adjective *good:*

She did well on the test.

In the second example, after a linking verb like *feel* you want a predicate adjective to describe the subject:

They felt bad about leaving their friends.

Error in Modification and Word Order

Reaching for the book, the ladder slipped out from under him.

A participial phrase at the beginning of the sentence should describe the subject of the sentence. Since it doesn't make sense to think of a ladder reaching for a book, this participle is left dangling with nothing to modify. The sentence needs some rewriting:

When he reached for the book, the ladder slipped out from under him.

Error in Parallelism

In his book on winter sports, the author discusses ice-skating, skiing, hockey, and how to fish in an ice-covered lake.

Logically, equal and similar ideas belong in similar form. This shows that they are equal. In this sentence, the author discusses four sports, and all four should be presented the same way:

In his book on winter sports, the author discusses ice skating, skiing, hockey, and fishing in an ice-covered lake.

Error in Diction or Idiom

The affects of the storm could be seen everywhere.

Your ear for the language will help you handle these errors, especially if you are accustomed to reading standard English. These questions test you on words that are frequently misused, on levels of usage (informal versus formal), and on standard English idioms. In this example, the verb *affect,* meaning "to influence," has been confused with the noun *effect,* meaning "result."

The effects of the storm could be seen everywhere.

The exercises that follow will give you practice in answering the three types of questions you'll find on the Identifying Sentence Errors questions, Improving Sentence questions, and Improving Paragraph questions. When you have completed each exercise, check your answers against the answer key. Then, read the answer explanations for any questions you either answered incorrectly or omitted.

Practice Exercise

The sentences in this section may contain errors in grammar, usage, choice of words, or idioms. Either there is just one error in a sentence or the sentence is correct. Some words or phrases are underlined and lettered; everything else in the sentence is correct.

If an underlined word or phrase is incorrect, choose that letter; if the sentence is correct, select No error. Then blacken the appropriate space on your answer sheet.

Example:

The region has a climate so severe that (A) plants growing there (B) rarely had been (C) more than twelve inches high (D). No error (E)

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1. We were already (A) to leave for (B) the amusement park when John's car broke down (C); we were forced (D) to postpone our outing. No error (E)

2. By order of (A) the Student Council, the wearing of (B) slacks by we (C) girls in school has been permitted (D). No error (E)

3. Each (A) one of the dogs in the show require (B) a special (C) kind of (D) diet. No error (E)

4. The major difficulty confronting (A) the authorities was (B) the reluctance of the people to talk (C); they had been warned not to say nothing (D) to the police. No error (E)

5. If I were (A) you, I would never permit him (B) to take part (C) in such an exhausting and painful (D) activity. No error (E)

6. Stanford White, who (A) is one of America's most notable (B) architects, have designed (C) many famous buildings, among them (D) the original Madison Square Garden. No error (E)

7. The notion of allowing (A) the institution of (B) slavery to continue to (C) exist in a democratic society had no appeal to either the violent followers of John Brown nor (D) the peaceful disciples of Sojourner Truth. No error (E)

8. Some students prefer (A) watching filmstrips to textbooks (B) because they feel uncomfortable with (C) the presentation of (D) information in a non-oral form. No error (E)

9. There (A) was so much conversation in back of (B) me that (C) I couldn't (D) hear the actors on the stage. No error (E)

10. This book is too (A) elementary; it can help (B) neither you nor (C) I (D). No error (E)

11. In a way we (A) may say that (B) we have reached (C) the end of (D) the Industrial Revolution. No error (E)

12. Although (A) the books are altogether (B) on the shelf, they (C) are not arranged in any kind of (D) order. No error (E)

13. The reason for (A) my prolonged absence (B) from class was (C) because (D) I was ill for three weeks. No error (E)

14. According to (A) researchers, the weapons and work implements used by (B) Cro-Magnon hunters appear being (C) actually quite (D) "modern." No error (E)

15. Since we were caught completely unawares (A), the affect (B) of Ms. Rivera's remarks was startling (C); some were shocked, but (D) others were angry. No error (E)

16. The committee had intended (A) both you and I (B) to speak at the assembly; however, (C) only (D) one of us will be able to talk. No error (E)

17. The existence of rundown "welfare hotels" in which (A) homeless families reside (B) at enormous cost to (C) the taxpayer provides a shameful commentary of (D) America's commitment to house the poor. No error (E)

18. We have heard that the principal (A) has decided whom (B) the prize winners will be (C) and (D) will announce the names in the assembly today. No error (E)

19. As soon as (A) the sun had rose (B) over (C) the mountains, the valley became unbearably hot (D) and stifling. No error (E)

20. They (A) are both excellent books (B), but this one is (C) best (D). No error (E)

21. Although the news had come (A) as a surprise to all (B) in the room, both Jane and Oprah tried to do her (C) work as though (D) nothing had happened. No error (E)

22. Even (A) well-known fashion designers have difficulty staying on top from one season to another (B) because of (C) changeable moods (D) and needs in the marketplace. No error (E)

23. Arms control has been under discussion (A) for decades with the former Soviet Union, but (B) solutions are still (C) alluding (D) the major powers. No error (E)

24. Perhaps sports enthusiasts are realizing that (A) jogging is not easy on (B) joints and tendons, for the latest (C) fad is being walking (D). No error (E)

25. Technological advances can cause (A) factual data to become obsolete within a short time (B); yet (C), students should concentrate on reasoning skills (D), not facts. No error (E)

26. If (A) anyone cares to join (B) me in this campaign, either (C) now or in the near future, they (D) will be welcomed gratefully. No error (E)

27. The poems with which (A) he occasionally desired to regale (B) the fashionable world were invariably bad (C)—stereotyped, bombastic, and even ludicrous (D). No error (E)

28. Ever since (A) the quality of (B) teacher education came under public scrutiny, suggestions for upgrading (C) the profession are abounding (D). No error (E)

29. Because (A) the door was locked and bolted, the police were (B) forced to break (C) into the apartment through (D) the bedroom window. No error (E)

30. I will (A) always (B) remember you (C) standing by (D) me offering me encouragement. No error (E)

31. With special training, capuchin monkeys can enable (A) quadriplegics as well as (B) other handicapped individuals to become (C) increasingly independent (D). No error (E)

32. Contrary to (A) what had previously been reported, the conditions governing (B) the truce between Libya and Chad arranged by (C) the United Nations has (D) not yet been revealed. No error (E)

33. Avid readers generally either admire or (A) dislike Ernest Hemingway's journalistic style of (B) writing; few have (C) no opinion of him (D). No error (E)

34. In 1986, the nuclear disaster at Chernobyl

has aroused (A) intense speculation about (B) the
long-term effects of (C) radiation that continued for
the better part of (D) a year. No error (E)

35. Howard Hughes, who (A) became (B) the subject of bizarre
rumors as a result of (C) his extreme reclusiveness,
was well-known as an aviator, industrialist, and
in producing motion pictures (D). No error (E)

Some or all parts of the following sentences are underlined. The first answer choice, (A), simply repeats the underlined part of the sentence. The other four choices present four alternative ways to phrase the underlined part. Select the answer that produces the most effective sentence, one that is clear and exact, and blacken the appropriate space on your answer sheet. In selecting your choice, be sure that it is standard written English, and that it expresses the meaning of the original sentence.

Example:

The first biography of author Eudora Welty came out in 1998 and she was 89 years old at the time.

(A) and she was 89 years old at the time
(B) at the time when she was 89
(C) upon becoming an 89 year old
(D) when she was 89
(E) at the age of 89 years old

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36. The child is neither encouraged to be critical or to examine all the evidence before forming an opinion.

(A) neither encouraged to be critical or to examine
(B) neither encouraged to be critical nor to examine
(C) either encouraged to be critical or to examine
(D) encouraged either to be critical nor to examine
(E) not encouraged either to be critical or to examine

37. The process by which the community influence the actions of its members is known as social control.

(A) influence the actions of its members
(B) influences the actions of its members
(C) had influenced the actions of its members
(D) influences the actions of their members
(E) will influence the actions of its members

38. Play being recognized as an important factor improving mental and physical health and thereby reducing human misery and poverty.

(A) Play being recognized as
(B) By recognizing play as
(C) Their recognizing play as
(D) Recognition of it being
(E) Play is recognized as

39. To be sure, there would be scarcely any time left over for other things if school children would have been expected to have considered all sides of every matter, on which they hold opinions.

(A) would have been expected to have considered
(B) should have been expected to have considered
(C) were expected to consider
(D) will be expected to have considered
(E) were expected to be considered

40. Using it wisely, leisure promotes health, efficiency and happiness.

(A) Using it wisely
(B) If it is used wisely
(C) Having used it wisely
(D) Because of its wise use
(E) Because of usefulness

41. In giving expression to the play instincts of the human race, new vigor and effectiveness are afforded by recreation to the body and to the mind.

(A) new vigor and effectiveness are afforded by recreation to the body and to the mind
(B) recreation affords new vigor and effectiveness to the body and to the mind
(C) there are afforded new vigor and effectiveness to the body and to the mind
(D) by recreation the body and the mind are afforded new vigor and effectiveness
(E) to the body and to the mind afford new vigor and effectiveness to themselves by recreation

42. Depending on skillful suggestion, argument is seldom used in advertising.
    (A) Depending on skillful suggestion, argument is seldom used in advertising.
    (B) Argument is seldom used in advertising, which depends instead on skillful suggestion.
    (C) Skillful suggestion is depended on by advertisers instead of argument.
    (D) Suggestion, which is more skillful, is used in place of argument by advertisers.
    (E) Instead of suggestion, depending on argument is used by skillful advertisers.

43. When this war is over, no nation will either be isolated in war or peace.
    (A) either be isolated in war or peace
    (B) be either isolated in war or peace
    (C) be isolated in neither war nor peace
    (D) be isolated either in war or in peace
    (E) be isolated neither in war or peace

44. Thanks to the prevailing westerly winds, dust blowing east from the drought-stricken plains travels halfway across the continent to fall on the cities of the East Coast.
    (A) blowing east from the drought-stricken plains
    (B) that, blowing east from the drought-stricken plains,
    (C) from the drought-stricken plains and blows east
    (D) that is from the drought-stricken plains blowing east
    (E) blowing east that is from the plains that are drought-stricken

45. Americans are learning that their concept of a research worker toiling alone in a laboratory and who discovers miraculous cures has been highly idealized and glamorized.
    (A) toiling alone in a laboratory and who discovers miraculous cures
    (B) toiling alone in a laboratory and discovers miraculous cures
    (C) toiling alone in a laboratory to discover miraculous cures
    (D) who toil alone in the laboratory and discover miraculous cures
    (E) has toiled alone hoping to discover miraculous cures

46. However many mistakes have been made in our past, the tradition of America, not only the champion of freedom but also fair play, still lives among millions who can see light and hope scarcely anywhere else.
    (A) not only the champion of freedom but also fair play
    (B) the champion of not only freedom but also of fair play
    (C) the champion not only of freedom but also of fair play
    (D) not only the champion but also freedom and fair play
    (E) not the champion of freedom only, but also fair play

47. Examining the principal movements sweeping through the world, it can be seen that they are being accelerated by the war.
    (A) Examining the principal movements sweeping through the world, it can be seen
    (B) Having examined the principal movements sweeping through the world, it can be seen
    (C) Examining the principal movements sweeping through the world can be seen
    (D) Examining the principal movements sweeping through the world, we can see
    (E) It can be seen examining the principal movements sweeping through the world

48. The FCC is broadening its view on what constitutes indecent programming, radio stations are taking a closer look at their broadcasters' materials.
    (A) The FCC is broadening its view on what constitutes indecent programming
    (B) The FCC, broadening its view on what constitutes indecent programming, has caused
    (C) The FCC is broadening its view on what constitutes indecent programming, as a result
    (D) Since the FCC is broadening its view on what constitutes indecent programming
    (E) The FCC, having broadened its view on what constitutes indecent programming

49. As district attorney, Elizabeth Holtzman not only had the responsibility of supervising a staff of dedicated young lawyers but she had the task of maintaining good relations with the police also.
    (A) but she had the task of maintaining good relations with the police also
    (B) but she also had the task of maintaining good relations with the police
    (C) but also had the task of maintaining good relations with the police
    (D) but she had the task to maintain good relations with the police also
    (E) but also she had the task to maintain good relations with the police

50. Many politicians are now trying to take uncontroversial positions on issues; the purpose being to allow them to appeal to as wide a segment of the voting population as possible.
    (A) issues; the purpose being to allow them to appeal
    (B) issues in order to appeal
    (C) issues, the purpose is to allow them to appeal
    (D) issues and the purpose is to allow them to appeal
    (E) issues; that was allowing them to appeal

The passage below is the unedited draft of a student's essay. Parts of the essay need to be rewritten to make the meaning clearer and more precise. Read the essay carefully.

The essay is followed by six questions about changes that might improve all or part of the organization, development, sentence structure, use of language, appropriateness to the audience, or use of standard written English. In each case, choose the answer that most clearly and effectively expresses the student's intended meaning. Indicate your choice by blackening the corresponding space on the answer sheet.

[1] Throughout history, people have speculated about the future. [2] Will it be a utopia? they wondered. [3] Will injustice and poverty be eliminated? [4] Will people accept ethnic diversity, learning to live in peace? [5] Will the world be clean and unpolluted? [6] Or will technology aid us in creating a trap for ourselves we cannot escape, for example such as the world in 1984? [7] With the turn of the millennium just around the corner these questions are in the back of our minds.

[8] Science fiction often portrays the future as a technological Garden of Eden. [9] With interactive computers, TVs and robots at our command, we barely need to lift a finger to go to school, to work, to go shopping, and education is also easy and convenient. [10] Yet, the problems of the real twentieth century seem to point in another direction. [11] The environment, far from improving, keeps deteriorating. [12] Wars and other civil conflicts breakout regularly. [13] The world's population is growing out of control. [14] The majority of people on earth live in poverty. [15] Many of them are starving. [16] Illiteracy is a problem in most poor countries. [17] Diseases and malnourishment is very common. [18] Rich countries like the U.S.A. don't have the resources to help the "have-not" countries.

[19] Instead, think instead of all the silly inventions such as tablets you put in your toilet tank to make the water blue, or electric toothbrushes. [20] More money is spent on space and defense than on education and health care. [21] Advancements in agriculture can produce enough food to feed the whole country, yet people in the U.S. are starving.

[22] Although the USSR is gone, the nuclear threat continues from small countries like Iraq. [23] Until the world puts its priorities straight, we can't look for a bright future in the twenty-first century, despite the rosy picture painted for us by the science fiction writers.

51. In the context of paragraph 1, which of the following is the best revision of sentence 6?
    (A) Or will technology create a trap for ourselves from which we cannot escape, for example the world in *1984*?
    (B) Or will technology aid people in creating a trap for themselves that they cannot escape; for example, the world in *1984*?
    (C) Or will technology create a trap from which there is no escape, as it did in the world in *1984*?
    (D) Or will technology trap us in an inescapable world, for example, it did so in the world of *1984*?
    (E) Perhaps technology will aid people in creating a trap for themselves from which they cannot escape, just as they did it in the world of *1984*.

52. With regard to the essay as a whole, which of the following best describes the writer's intention in paragraph 1?
    (A) To announce the purpose of the essay
    (B) To compare two ideas discussed later in the essay
    (C) To take a position on the essay's main issue
    (D) To reveal the organization of the essay
    (E) To raise questions that will be answered in the essay

53. Which of the following is the best revision of the underlined segment of sentence 9 below?

[9] With interactive computers, TVs and robots at our command, we barely need to lift a finger to go to school, to work, to go shopping, and education is also easy and convenient.

(A) and to go shopping, while education is also easy and convenient
(B) to go shopping, and getting an education is also easy and convenient
(C) to go shopping as well as educating ourselves are all easy and convenient
(D) to shop, and an easy and convenient education
(E) to shop, and to get an easy and convenient education

54. Which of the following is the most effective way to combine sentences 14, 15, 16, and 17?

(A) The majority of people on earth are living in poverty and are starving, with illiteracy, and disease and being malnourished are also a common problems.
(B) Common problems for the majority of people on earth are poverty, illiteracy, diseases, malnourishment, and many are illiterate.
(C) The majority of people on earth are poor, starving, sick, malnourished and illiterate.
(D) Common among the poor majority on earth is poverty, starvation, disease, malnourishment, and illiteracy.
(E) The majority of the earth's people living in poverty with starvation, disease, malnourishment and illiteracy a constant threat.

55. In the context of the sentences that precede and follow sentence 19, which of the following is the most effective revision of sentence 19 ?

(A) Instead they are devoting resources on silly inventions such as tablets to make toilet tank water blue or electric toothbrushes.
(B) Instead, they waste their resources on producing silly inventions like electric toothbrushes and tablets for bluing toilet tank water.
(C) Think of all the silly inventions: tablets you put in your toilet tank to make the water blue and electric toothbrushes.
(D) Instead, tablets you put in your toilet tank to make the water blue or electric toothbrushes are examples of useless products on the market today.
(E) Instead of spending on useful things, think of all the silly inventions such as tablets you put in your toilet tank to make the water blue or electric toothbrushes.

56. Which of the following revisions would most improve the overall coherence of the essay?

(A) Move sentence 7 to paragraph 2
(B) Move sentence 10 to paragraph 1
(C) Move sentence 22 to paragraph 2
(D) Delete sentence 8
(E) Delete sentence 23

Answer Key

1.	**A**	13.	**D**	25.	**C**	37.	**B**	49.	**C**
2.	**C**	14.	**C**	26.	**D**	38.	**E**	50.	**B**
3.	**B**	15.	**B**	27.	**E**	39.	**C**	51.	**C**
4.	**D**	16.	**B**	28.	**D**	40.	**B**	52.	**E**
5.	**E**	17.	**D**	29.	**E**	41.	**B**	53.	**E**
6.	**C**	18.	**B**	30.	**C**	42.	**B**	54.	**C**
7.	**D**	19.	**B**	31.	**E**	43.	**D**	55.	**B**
8.	**B**	20.	**D**	32.	**D**	44.	**A**	56.	**C**
9.	**B**	21.	**C**	33.	**D**	45.	**C**		
10.	**D**	22.	**E**	34.	**A**	46.	**C**		
11.	**E**	23.	**D**	35.	**D**	47.	**D**		
12.	**B**	24.	**D**	36.	**E**	48.	**D**		

Answer Explanations

1. A Error in diction. Should be *all ready. All ready* means the group is ready; *already* means prior to a given time, previously.

2. C Error in pronoun case. Should be *us.* The expression *us girls* is the object of the preposition *by.*

3. B Error in subject-verb agreement. Should be *requires.* Verb should agree with the subject (*each one*).

4. D Should be *to say anything. Not to say nothing* is a double negative.

5. E Sentence is correct.

6. C Error in subject-verb agreement. Since the subject is Stanford White (singular), change *have designed* to *has designed.*

7. D Error in use of correlatives. Change *nor* to *or.* The correct form of the correlative pairs *either* with *or.*

8. B Error in parallel structure. Change *textbooks* to *reading textbooks.* To have parallel structure, the linked sentence elements must share the same grammatical form.

9. B Error in diction. Change *in back of* to *behind.*

10. D Error in pronoun case. Should be *me.* Pronoun is the object of the verb *can help.*

11. E Sentence is correct.

12. B Error in diction. Should be *all together. All together* means in a group; *altogether* means entirely.

13. D Improper use of *because.* Change to *that* (*The reason . . . was that . . . .*).

14. C Incorrect verbal. Change the participle *being* to the infinitive *to be.*

15. B Error in diction. Change *affect* (a verb meaning to influence or pretend) to *effect* (a noun meaning result).

16. B Error in pronoun case. Should be *me.* Subjects of infinitives are in the objective case.

17. D Error in idiom. Change *commentary of* to *commentary on.*

18. B Error in pronoun case. Should be *who.* The pronoun is the predicate complement of *will be* and is in the nominative case.

19. B Should be *had risen.* The past participle of the verb *to rise* is *risen.*

20. D Error in comparison of modifiers. Should be *better.* Do not use the superlative when comparing two things.

21. C Error in pronoun-number agreement. Should be *their* instead of *her.* The antecedent of the pronoun is *Jane and Oprah* (plural).

22. E Sentence is correct.

23. D Error in diction. Change *alluding* (meaning to refer indirectly) to *eluding* (meaning to evade).

24. D Confusion of verb and gerund (verbal noun). Change *is being walking* to *is walking.*

25. C Error in coordination and subordination. Change *yet* to *therefore* or another similar connector to clarify the connection between the clauses.

26. D Error in pronoun-number agreement. Should be *he or she.* The antecedent of the pronoun is *anyone* (singular).

27. E Sentence is correct.

28. D Error in sequence of tenses. Change *are abounding* to *have abounded.* The present perfect tense talks about an action that occurs at one time, but is seen in relation to another time.

29. E Sentence is correct.

30. C Error in pronoun case. Should be *your.* The pronoun modifying a gerund (verbal noun) should be in the possessive case.

31. E Sentence is correct.

32. D Error in subject-verb agreement. Since the subject is *conditions* (plural), change *has* to *have.*

33. D Error in pronoun. Since the sentence speaks about Hemingway's style rather than about Hemingway, the phrase should read *of it,* not *of him.*

34. A Error in sequence of tenses. Change *has aroused* to *aroused.* The present perfect tense (*has aroused*) is used for indefinite time. In this sentence, the time is defined as *the better part of a year.*

35. D Lack of parallel structure. Change *in producing motion pictures* to *motion picture producer.*

36. E This question involves two aspects of correct English. *Neither* should be followed by *nor; either* by *or.* Choices A and D are, therefore,

incorrect. The words *neither . . . nor* and *either . . . or* should be placed before the two items being discussed—*to be critical* and *to examine*. Choice E meets both requirements.

37. B This question tests agreement. Errors in subject-verb agreement and pronoun-number agreement are both involved. *Community* (singular) needs a singular verb, *influences.* Also, the pronoun that refers to *community* should be singular *(its*).

38. E Error in following conventions. This is an incomplete sentence or fragment. The sentence needs a verb to establish a principal clause. Choice E provides the verb (*is recognized*) and presents the only complete sentence in the group.

39. C *Would have been expected* is incorrect as a verb in a clause introduced by the conjunction *if. Had been expected* or *were expected* is preferable. *To have considered* does not follow correct sequence of tense and should be changed to *to consider.*

40. B Error in modification and word order. One way of correcting a dangling participle is to change the participial phrase to a clause. Choices B and D substitute clauses for the phrase. However, Choice D changes the meaning of the sentence. Choice B is correct.

41. B Error in modification and word order. As it stands, the sentence contains a dangling modifier. This is corrected by making *recreation* the subject of the sentence, in the process switching from the passive to the active voice. Choice E also provides a subject for the sentence; however, the meaning of the sentence is changed in choice E.

42. B Error in modification and word order. As presented, the sentence contains a dangling participle, *depending.* Choice B corrects this error. The other choices change the emphasis presented by the author.

43. D Error in word order. *Either . . . or* should precede the two choices offered (*in war* and *in peace*).

44. A Sentence is correct.

45. C Error in parallelism. In the underlined phrase, you will find two modifiers of *worker-toiling* and *who discovers.* The first is a participial phrase and the second a clause. This results in an error in parallel structure. Choice B also has an error in parallel structure. Choice C corrects this by eliminating one of the modifiers of *worker.* Choice D corrects the error in parallel structure but introduces an error in agreement between subject and verb—*who* (singular) and *toil* (plural). Choice E changes the tense and also the meaning of the original sentence.

46. C Error in parallelism. Parallel structure requires that *not only* and *but also* immediately precede the words they limit.

47. D Error in modification and word order. Choices A, B, and E are incorrect because of the dangling participle. Choice C is incoherent. Choice D correctly eliminates the dangling participle by introducing the subject *we.*

48. D Error in comma splice. The punctuation in Choices A and C creates a run-on sentence. Choices B and E are both ungrammatical. Choice D corrects the run-on sentence by changing the beginning clause into the adverb clause that starts with the subordinating conjunction *since.*

49. C Error in parallelism. Since the words *not only* immediately precede the verb in the first half of the sentence, the words *but also* should immediately precede the verb in the second half. This error in parallel structure is corrected in choice C.

50. B Error in coordination and subordination. The punctuation in choices A, C, D, and E creates an incomplete sentence or fragment. Choice B corrects the error by linking the elements with *in order to.*

51. C Choice A is awkward and shifts the pronoun usage in the paragraph from third to first person. Choice B is awkward and contains a semicolon error. A semicolon is used to separate two independent clauses. The material after the semicolon is a sentence fragment. Choice C is succinctly and accurately expressed. It is the best answer. Choice D contains a comma splice between *world* and *for.* A comma may not be used to join two independent clauses. Choice E is awkwardly expressed and contains the pronoun *it,* which lacks a clear referent.

52. E Choice A indirectly describes the purpose of paragraph 1 but does not identify the writer's main intention. Choices B, C, and D fail to describe the writer's main intention. Choice E accurately describes the writer's main intention. It is the best answer.

53. E Choice A is grammatically correct but cumbersome. Choice B contains an error in parallel construction. The clause that begins *and getting* is not grammatically parallel to the previous items on the list. Choice C contains a mixed construction. The first and last parts of the sentence are grammatically unrelated. Choice D contains faulty parallel structure. Choice E is correct and accurately expressed. It is the best answer.

54. C Choice A is wordy and awkwardly expressed. Choice B contains an error in parallel structure. The clause *and many are illiterate* is not grammatically parallel to the previous items on the list of problems. Choice C is concise and accurately expressed. It is the best answer. Choice D is concise, but it contains an error in subject-verb agreement. The subject is *poverty, starvation . . . etc.,* which requires a plural verb; the verb *is* is singular. Choice E is a sentence fragment; it has no main verb.

55. B Choice A contains an error in idiom. The standard phrase is *devoting to,* not *devoting on.* Choice B ties sentence 19 to the previous sentence and is accurately expressed. It is the best answer. Choice C fails to improve the coherence of the paragraph. Choice D is unrelated to the context of the paragraph. Choice E is insufficiently related to the context of the paragraph.

56. C Choice A should stay put because it provides a transition between the questions in paragraph 1 and the beginning of paragraph 2. Choice B is a pivotal sentence in paragraph 2 and should not be moved. Choice C fits the topics of paragraph 2, therefore, sentence 22 should be moved to paragraph 2. Choice C is the best answer. Choice D is needed as an introductory sentence in paragraph 2. It should not be deleted. Choice E provides the essay with a meaningful conclusion and should not be deleted.